

Jack Lubin
Failure CV

In a CV, we highlight all the things that we want to brag about: our education, our fellowships, our awards won, etc. This makes sense of course, everyone wants to look good and no one wants to look bad. Especially when we are applying to a job or a grant or a fellowship, we want to put our best foot forward and show the admission committee or grant committee why they should hire us or give us funding. Usually in academia, professionals will post a CV to their website, so that anyone can read them and get a good picture of the general career arc of the person.

But a CV is deceptive. Because we only want to show our best side, we only include things that make us look good. A CV is only one side of the picture of a career. Even the most successful professionals meet a lot of rejection over the course of their career. But we often try to bury these rejections and failures. A failure CV is supposed to be the opposite of a regular CV. It intentionally highlights the low-lights of a career. It should show missed opportunities, rejections of all kinds, general failures, and more. The idea is to be honest, to show that even successful people experience non-success. They should be inspirational: look at how many rejections even very successful people have had. Then when you get a rejection or have a failure, it can be more fairly put into context within your own career. Failure CVs spread humility and honesty, and show the downs that go with the ups of a career.

I've put this Failure CV together as an example. It is by no means complete, mostly because, like most of us, I try to not to remember my failures and rejections, and I certainly did not keep records of them in the same way that I did (and do) with my successes (now I will keep track of both and continually update this Failure CV in the same way that I updated my regular CV).

I hope that someone reading this will see that my career (while by no means "successful" or "exceptional" for someone at a similar stage of career), will see that I have hit many roadblocks along the way. And then the reader will know that any roadblocks they hit can be overcome and put into context.

I hope that the reader who peruses my CV will also look over this Failure CV. And, like with my regular CV, I am happy to talk about this Failure CV as well.

Best, Jack
June 22, 2022

Last Updated: May. 2025

Schools Rejected From:

- ***Undergrad:*** Vanderbilt (Rejected early decision, later accepted on transfer), Duke, Harvard, Dartmouth, Rice, Stanford
- ***Transfer:*** UPenn, Cornell, Columbia
- ***Graduate:*** Harvard, UC Berkeley, UCLA, UC Santa Barbara, UC San Diego, Arizona, Arizona State, Texas Austin, Denver U, Michigan, Ohio State, Washington, and Colorado.
 - I was rejected from every school I applied to, except one...UCI! While it's nice to have options, you can only attend one school so you only need one acceptance.

Jobs Rejected From

- Basically every major consulting firm (Deloitte, Bain & Co, KPGM, E&Y, etc)
- Various hedge funds (when I thought I might want to do this kind of work, glad it didn't work out!)
- An internship with the Nashville Predators for stats work (I really wanted this one!)
- Approximately 15 REUs across 2 summers
- The Grand Canyon Astronomer In Residence (2024 and 2025)
- 2023 Academic Cycle:
 - Percival Lowell Postdoctoral Fellowship (short-listed)
 - NASA Hubble Fellowship
 - 51 Pegasi b Fellowship
 - NSF Astronomy and Astrophysics Postdoctoral Fellowship
 - Caltech's Center for Comparative Planetary Evolution Postdoctoral Fellowship
 - Caltech's Prize Fellowship in Observational Astrophysics
- 2024 Academic Cycle:
 - NASA Hubble Fellowship
 - 51 Pegasi b Fellowship
 - U. Minnesota faculty
 - U. Maryland faculty
- 2025 Academic Cycle:
 - NASA Hubble Fellowship
 - Carnegie Observatories Fellowship

- Flatiron Institute CCA Research Fellowship
- Flatiron Institute CCA Software Fellowship
- STScI Giacconi Fellowship
- Princeton Russell Fellowship
- Princeton Exoplanet AI Fellowship
- Northwestern’s CIERA Fellowship
- MIT Torres Fellowship

Fellowship/Grants rejected

- NASA ExoExplorers, 2021 and 2022 (third try in 2023 I did receive it)
- NSF Grad Research Fellowship 2019 (not even honorable mention)
- NASA Future Investigators Fellowship (FINNEST), 2019 and 2021
- NASA EPRV ROSES 2021
- At least 2 NOIRLab telescope time proposals
- At least 1 NASA Keck proposal
- At least 1 UCO Keck proposal

Other

- Conferences where I submitted an abstract asking for a talk and got rejected or offered a poster instead: EPRV5, ExoPAG 29, ExSoCal 2023, ExSoCal 2024, Extreme Solar Systems 5, EPRV6